Exploring Multidimensional Influencer Culture through Marxian Lens :

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In our digital, post-pandemic age, where Instagram "likes" act as a form of currency and viral TikTok trends affect consumer behavior, the rise of influencer culture begs the question: Are we witnessing a societal revolution of self-expression and creativity, or is it simply a Capitalist illusion? As individuals leverage their online presence to garner followers and promote products, it has become clear that influencer culture's impact goes beyond that of self-enjoyment and plays a larger role in the shaping of social dynamics.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Through the dual lens of Marxist analysis, this paper aims to provide a nuanced understanding of the multidimensional nature of influencer culture. First, I will introduce Marxian philosophy, drawing from his work "Capital" and its relevance to this social phenomenon. Focusing on his theory of Commodity Fetishism, I argue that through the commodification of identities and lifestyles for profit, influencers obscure the social relations between themselves and their audiences. I argue that commodification occurs through two methods: 1) Influencer Marketing and 2) Influencer Branding. This perspective implies that influencer culture is not merely a reflection of individual expression and creativity but instead is incentivized by economic structures and Capitalist ideologies.

A. What is an "Influencer"

According to the Cambridge Dictionary, an influencer is "a person or group that had the ability to influence the behavior or opinion of others" (Cambridge). We will use this definition for this paper, but with a slight addition. Within the scope of this paper, the term "influencer" will specifically refer to individuals with a strong online social media presence. There are two types of influencer categorizations: the "Celebrity influencer" and the "Micro-influencer."

On the "celebrity-influencer" scale – those with a fan base in the tens (if not hundreds) of millions, whose fame extends beyond social media and stems from pursuits like acting, singing, or sports—it becomes evident that personal profit motives primarily drive their online engagement. This can include those like the Kardashians, artists like Taylor Swift, sports personas like Ronaldo or Serena Williams, and actresses like Ann Hathaway or Zendaya, all considered to be figureheads of contemporary celebrity influencer culture. With "collaborations, " brands can work alongside influencers by promoting a personalized "line" – e.g., you can buy Olivia Rodrigo Crumble Cookies or Millie-Bobby Brown Converse sneakers. Other times, influencers create their own brands—e.g., SKIMS by Kim Kardashian (valued now at 4 billion) or Rhianna's make-up brand "Fenty Beauty," which made $72 million in media value in the first month and $100 million in sales in the first 40 days (*NewYorkTimes*). Influencers of this form often make their primary income through other devices–i.e., acting– and their social media presence is a mere addition.

The other type of online influencer is the "Micro-Influencer," the ordinary, everyday people who grew a significantly sizeable following base (in the tens of thousands at a minimum) through the frequent posting of content. Often, Micro-Influencers end up relying heavily upon their platform for income *(Vrontis et al.)*. Micro-influencers can be further categorized based on the context they promote: personal art to, home-cooked recipes to magic tricks, etc. As social media "fame" rises in popularity, so does the probing question: are influencers posting for the sake of engaging with their community, for creative self-expression, and for genuine endorsement of the brands they promote? Or is the digital age dominated purely by profit-incentivized motivations?

2. THE MARXIST PERSPECTIVE

The Marxian analysis of influencer culture highlights how influencers commodify their identities for personal profit. In this section, I first provide a brief overview of the concept of the commodity and its significance to the Capitalist system. Then, I explore how value is determined by exchanging these commodities and the consequential effect of Commodity Fetishism. I offer an understanding of how Capitalist production transforms societal relationships into economic transactions, leading to the alienation of labor and the devaluation of individual beings. Finally, I explain the relevance of my argument– that by treat-

ing their personal lives as marketable commodities, influencers, like a Marxist Capitalist, seek only to maximize profit through exploitation, capitalizing upon their ability to attract audiences and ultimately defacing authentic social relations between themselves, the producers, and their audience, the consumers.

A. The Marxist Commodity

The commodity is an "external object" that "satisfies human needs of any kind" *(Marx 125*). Simply put, the commodity refers to *a thing* – e.g., a physical product like clothing or as a form of entertainment– that individuals consume for their own satisfaction. The commodity has a dual character, with 1) the Use-value and 2) the Exchange Value.

The foremost, Use Value, refers to the usefulness or utility of the commodity, as its namesake suggests. It is a qualitative aspect that is, by its nature, part of the commodity's "physical body" *(Marx 126)*. In short, the concept of "usefulness" is wholly contingent upon the commodity's existence and is actualized through its consumption or utilization.

The second characteristic, the Exchange Value, is the value of the commodity in relation to other commodities. Exchange Value is expressed via a quantitative relation, a ratio or proportion of a certain type, e.g., price, and represents the relationship between different commodities in the market *(Marx 126,168)*. The Exchange Value is determined by the amount of labor time "socially necessary" for its production, i.e., that is required to produce the commodity on average, under conditions "normal" for the society, with an average degree of skill *(Marx 129,168, 202,434, 465*). Labor itself is defined as the source of value in commodities, measured by labor-time, a quantity measured in scalar terms such as hours, days, months, etc. *(Marx 129, 168, 202*). Labor is not merely a means of producing goods for consumption purposes alone but functions as a mode that influences social relationships. There are two types of labor under the Marxian framework: Concrete and Abstract. Abstract Labor, in particular, stresses the social nature of labor in creating value and, thus, has great significance in the Capitalist economy.

Marx argues that under the Capitalist system, Exchange Value is prioritized over Use Value *(Marx 169, 176*)**.** It is important to note that labor is, like the commodity, a duality composed of Abstract and Concrete labor, which is, foremost, defined as the expenditure of labor used in production measured by the aforementioned socially necessary time required to produce the commodity *(Marx 131-133, 166-169)*. Unlike Concrete Labor, Abstract Labor is not measured by the particular skills or physical efforts performed by the workers in production *(Marx 131-133).* Under the Capitalist system, then, a homogenization of labor occurs, in which abstract labor "homogenizes" a diverse range of concrete labor under one "common substance" *(Marx 139, 141,151).* In the economy, this "one common substance" usually appears in the form of money, but in the world of social media, I argue that value is exchanged in the form of "likes." I will expand on this in a later section.

The domination of Exchange-Value over Use-Value gives rise to Commodity Fetishism, the phenomenon in which social relations between individuals become obscured, and individuals no longer view commodity exchange as a relationship between people but between commodities. When influencers produce content for the sake of profit maximization– and not for the instinct usefulness (use-value) of their content, it reflects the abstraction of labor, where the concrete labor of content creation becomes detached from its specific use and is instead valued primarily for its exchangeability *(Marx 159-161).* This is clearly exemplified when influencers promote brands that clearly do not "fit" with their online personality; for example, an influencer who is known for providing make-up tutorials suddenly posts a video for a pre-workout drink. In doing so, they no longer value the time they spend curating the post for the sake of the post but purely for promoting that good.

The distinction between abstract labor and concrete labor makes further clear the "conversion of things into persons and conversion of persons into things" *(Marx 209)*. This abstraction of labor in the digital sphere mirrors what occurs within the Capitalist economy, where the production process (in this case, the creation of the content) is detached from the end product.

3. TWO MODES OF INFLUENCER PRODUCTION

I argue that influencer culture has led to the commodification of social relations. Influencers present themselves as commodities through strategic branding and content promotion, with their personalities, lifestyles, and identities "packaged" for their audience to consume. This can be illustrated in two ways: 1) the Commodification of Identities/Lifestyles and 2) The Obscuration of Social Relations. First, I claim that there are two different yet often overlapping and interconnected modes of influencer production. The first is Influencer Marketing, and the second I referred to as Influencer Branding. Only through understanding these two forms of influencer production can we then understand how commodification occurs.

A. Influencer Marketing

The first form of commodification occurs explicitly through Influencer Marketing, in which influencers are directly paid by brands, companies, organizations, or social media platforms to promote and subtly advertise certain goods. This can appear as "shopping hauls" or "Amazon Must-Haves," where influencers try on clothes or showcase products, sending the links for sale in the comment section. This can take a more subtle route as well in the form of using certain hair or makeup products in "Get Ready With Me" videos, where influencers perhaps do not explicitly state they are promoting a good by doing so just by using them.

It may even appear that influencers are not "producing" a good—perhaps they are only providing makeup tutorials or advocating for a healthy lifestyle through gym workouts and recipes. However, what initially is an innocent pastime can be a promotional endeavor in disguise; i.e., makeup tutorials and gym routines can subtly become promotional campaigns for cosmetic brands and gym memberships.

For example, programs such as the TikTok "Greater Rewards Program" now exist, which pay those with a 10k or more following base for each one-minute video they create. Programs such as these exemplify the domination of the Exchange Value of content creation over its Use Value.

The domination of Exchange-Value over Use-Value in the Capitalist system gives rise to Commodity Fetishism, the phenomenon in which social relations between individuals become obscured, and individuals no longer view commodity exchange as a relationship between people but "between commodities" *(Marx 209)*. Commodity Fetishism leads to the alienation of producers, in which they feel disconnected from the goods they produce, perceiving them as objects for sale rather than for their own selves or creative expressions *(Marx 72,74,197,1007*). Vice versa, the consumers may feel alienated from the laborers involved in producing the items they consume. In the world

of social media influencing, the phenomenon of Commodity Fetishism becomes apparent as influencers begin to curate content for the sake of sale and profit – whether it is the literal promotion of brands and goods in the form of influencer marketing or in the less tangible "sale" of lifestyles and identities. In the same way, influencers can feel "detached" from their content or struggle to continuously fit the mold of their online curated personality, leading to a depersonalization of their identity in the eyes of the audience and to themselves.

As influencers continue to profit from their video reactions, the relationship between producer and audience becomes detached, almost inauthentic. As mentioned by Kim et al., as influencers engage more and more with profit-incentivized promotional videos, the receiving audience of such curated posts begins to question the influencer's authenticity, and feelings of mistrust increase, further leading to the separation between the influencer, the good, and the audience *(Kim et al.)*.

By "authenticity" between relations, I refer to the feelings of trust and the attribution of morally righteous characteristics upon the influencer by the consumer. Another way to describe this phenomenon more simply is to understand how perceived bias clouds the perceived reliability of the source of information. For example, take Bob, who is going out with friends. Bob is encountered by a club promoter on the side of the street, who attempts to persuade him to go in. Bob, recognizing that the club promoter has profit-incentivized motives (since he works for the organization), is more likely to be weary of receiving advice since the promoter has a clear bias and incentive to lie to benefit himself and his job. Bob turns the promoter down. However, when Bob later chats with a stranger at the bar who advocates for the same club, Bob accepts the advice and ends up going. Bob perceives the interaction with the stranger to be more "authentic" since there is no observable benefit for the stranger to promote the club unless he genuinely believes it is good; as such, Bob feels that the stranger is a more trustworthy source to receive advice from, and thus the social relationship between them is closer than that between Bob and the promoter – a relationship clouded by the perceived profit-bais.

The psychological difference between receiving advice from the promoter and the stranger is the same as that of an influencer who explicitly promotes a brand or good versus an influencer who does so more subtly. Now, of course, the club promoter could have genuinely supported the club they were advocating for; however, to Bob, the consumer, the mere notion that it was his job to do so obscured the perceived authenticity of the relationship. An influencer could genuinely enjoy the good they promote, but the very act of campaigning creates a barrier of perceived inauthenticity. In fact, influencers who explicitly influence versus those who do not could be equally profit-incentivized; however, it is important to note that the consumer's perception of the interaction is what holds great importance in defining whether the interaction is perceived as authentic. By engaging in influencer marketing, the influencer automatically creates an immaterial barrier between themselves and their audience.

B. Influencer Branding

The second form of production observed in the influencer culture is Influenced Branding. These influencers focus on "selling" specific lifestyles. They can appear in the form of individuals who post only "gym edit" workout videos—promoting the "healthy lifestyle"—to influencers who post content such as "Coffee-Shop Gems" and "Study Spot Finds"—promoting the "Romanticized College Student Life" lifestyle.

Influencers often undergo a shift in presenting carefully curated personalities and lifestyles for their audience, which are often heavily branded and commercialized, again leading to the aforementioned "conversion of things into persons and conversion of persons into things" *(Marx 209)*. In this way, however, unlike Influencer Marketing, in which the promotion of brands and products leads to the separation between the producer and her work, Influencer Branding exemplifies the commodification of a person's identity and lifestyle.

This is sometimes done through the concept of a digital "core" – such as that of a "Girly-Girl," "Old-Money," and even "That Girl." These "cores" simplify the influencer's image into neatly categorizable boxes. For example, an influencer promoting the "Girly Girl" lifestyle limits their digital presence to pastel colors, ruffles, bows, and LoveShackFancy-like dresses, whereas the "Old Money Aesethic" influence attempts to associate themselves with the preppy lifestyle of tennis courts, antique cars, navy blazers, and cable knit sweaters. "That Girl" influencers promote "clean" makeup looks, morning meditation, tidy rooms, and matcha green tea. In fitting their digital image to one of these online aesthetics, it becomes clear that the commodification extends beyond that of the products being endorsed in the content to encompass the influencer's entire way of life.

However, these arguments focusing on Influencer Marketing and Influencer Branding are geared towards those with significant following bases–usually in the millions or hundreds of millions of followers. As such, brands actively seek collaboration with them. However, a problem arises. It is clear that social media sites have a user base of millions, and people constantly post, regardless of whether they make monetary profit or not. These apps and brands are not paying every user on the site–just those they deem worthy of being "verifiable" influencers. Why, then, do people post if it is not initially profit-incentivized? This poses a key concern against my argument.

4. MONEY, "LIKES" AND SOCIAL CURRENCY:

For Micro-Influencers specifically, initial posting would not necessarily be profit-based. Remember that brands only actively pursue influencers with substantial followings, and platforms compensate content creators who have already amassed a minimum threshold of followers. But micro-influencers join social media with a following base of zero, meaning no profit-based incentive for them. If influencer culture perpetuates Capitalist ideologies and all posts and videos are financially incentivized, what motivates individuals to create content if they are not earning a profit? Recall that abstract labor determines Exchange Value, which is then expressed in money prices, which is the quantitative representation of abstract labor that permits the circulation of commodities in the economy *(Marx 202-204, 213-214).* Money, a commodity itself, serves as a "universal medium" of exchange and circulation, which functions directly as a measure of value *(Marx 168, 235, 277, 217, 214).* Money then gives rise to price, and the "lust for gold awakens" when the possibility of keeping hold of money, "the commodity as Exchange-Value," is realized *(Marx 213-125, 232)*. A commodity's value measures its attractiveness for all other aspects of material wealth, measuring, by extension, the "social wealth" of its owner *(Marx 299, 230).* In the digital era, and in Marxist terms, social media "likes" are a form of social currency and validity. The implication of a post with more "likes" is directly proportional to the overall appreciation and satisfaction the audience receives from watching, a

"symbolic representation" of social approval *(Marx 225, 226, 310).* Not only do they acquire this symbolic value through the literal function of gauging interest, but – users also equate a higher number of likes (and followers) with social status and popularity, similar to how commodities acquire value through Market Exchange. Social media platforms also facilitate the circulation and accumulation of likes, similar to how financial structures in the Capitalist system do for money in Capitalist economies. Therefore, individuals are still value-incentivized when they post, even if no physical profit is accrued; they gain worth and validity through virtual socially-based forms of currency.

A. What's so wrong about commodification in influencer culture?

The effects of influence culture Commodity Fetishism can have broader social ramifications on the part of the influencers themselves. Recall that under Marxist theory, producers in the Capitalist market seek to sell commodities at a profit, regardless of their use-value for society and similarity under influencer. First, in the context of digital influencer culture, this dynamic can have direct implications for the recipients of these products. For instance, as social media platforms gain traction among younger demographics, including children as young as seven or eight, influencers who prioritize production for profit may negatively impact the impressionable minds and behaviors of their audience. For example, influencers may endorse specific cosmetic brands solely for financial gain, often without considering that certain chemicals present in these products may not be suitable for the delicate skin of the young children who make up their fan base.

The effects of influence culture Commodity Fetishism can have broader social ramifications on the part of the influencers themselves. As Marx states, a laborer who feels alienated from their goods may lack feelings of worth and satisfaction in their jobs, viewing what they do– their labor– merely as a means to earn a wage rather than as a mode of personal fulfillment *(Marx 204, 212, 716).* In the social media culture framework, this can cause influencers to curate content they do not feel passionate about or, worse, can cause these individuals to feel dissatisfied with activities they once enjoyed. This can cause influencers to feel a sense of identity loss and feel as if they are no longer individuals in the eyes of the audience and themselves.

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